

movement. The Māori queen and longest reigning Māori monarch, Te Atairangikaahu, (reigned 1966–2006) is noted for raising the profile of the Māori at home and abroad. She also worked to revitalize Māori culture and language, and promoted better education and welfare among her people. Another woman, Whina Cooper, led a coalition of Māori groups in their first protest against the loss of Māori land in 1975.

### Emancipists and founders

In the early days of Sydney, women were in short supply. Female convicts were highly sought after both as domestic servants and as companions (see pp. 192–193). From 1788 to 1852, about 20,000 women were transported to Sydney but they were outnumbered by men by seven to one. More than 80 percent of those women transported had been convicted of petty crimes. Prostitution was not a transportable offense, and only a few women had been found guilty of violent crimes. Former convicts were known as emancipists, and while such a label was once considered a social stain, they are now seen as the founders of the state of Australia. Among them was Mary Reibey. She was convicted of stealing a horse at the age of 13 and arrived in Sydney from England in 1794. She became a successful businesswoman and property owner, and was a cofounder of the Bank of New South Wales. She has been featured on the Australian \$20 note since 1994.

The first settler women arrived in the 1790s with their husbands or families. The journals of these women give a particular insight into domestic life in the colony, including urban Sydney society, life in remote pastoral locations, and the settlers' interactions with indigenous women. Notable women include Elizabeth Macarthur, who landed in Sydney in 1790 and became a pioneer of Australia's merino wool industry, and Caroline Chisholm, who arrived in Sydney in 1838 and is known for her philanthropic work for the welfare of female immigrants.

From 1814, settlers started to arrive in greater numbers, along with missionaries. The men among them greatly outnumbered the women, so they were advised to bring a wife, and from the 1860s there were government incentives to encourage single British women to emigrate too. Large families were common and the white population grew rapidly. Among them were free thinkers who championed a number of social causes, such as Jane Atkinson, who arrived with her brother in New Zealand in 1850. A Unitarian and progressive thinker, she was active in the suffrage movement. Ellen Hewett arrived in New Zealand in 1854 with her family. Her memoir *Looking Back* (1914) is a vivid account of life for settler women during this period, and details the long separations, hard work, illnesses, and dangers of pioneer life.



#### ▲ From prison to prosperity

Mary Reibey was an Australian merchant and trader in the 19th century. Originally a convict deported to Australia, she became legendary as a successful businesswoman in the colony.

"ALL THAT **SEPARATES**,  
... **RACE** ... OR **SEX**, IS  
**INHUMAN** ... [AND]  
MUST BE **OVERCOME**."



KATE SHEPPARD, WOMEN'S SUFFRAGE CAMPAIGNER, ON HER SENSE OF EQUALITY AND JUSTICE IN SOCIETY